

MD-0001: Authority of the Specification over the Validator

Field	Value
ID	MD-0001
Type	MD - Maintainer Decision
Status	Accepted
Normative?	No. Records a governance principle; it does not itself define a dataset requirement.
Visibility	Public (standard governance)
Proposed date	2026-07-12
Accepted date	2026-07-26
Deciders	Steering Committee / maintainers (Princeton Medical Systems)
Related	GOVERNANCE.md; SPEC.md §1.2, §15.3; CONTRIBUTING.md

Decision

The relationship between the VIDS specification and its reference validator is fixed as follows:

1. **The Core Specification is authoritative.** It is the single source of dataset-conformance requirements.
2. **The validator implements the Core Specification.** It is an implementation of the standard, not the standard itself.
3. **Validator behavior does not establish normative requirements.** A dataset's conformance is defined by the specification; a validator result is evidence of conformance, not its definition. In particular, a validator that begins enforcing a field the specification already marks REQUIRED is performing a *conformance correction*, not introducing a *new requirement*.
4. **Divergence is resolved by correcting the appropriate artifact through governance.** Where the validator and the specification disagree, the specification governs. The divergence is closed by amending whichever artifact was wrong - usually the validator, occasionally the specification via errata - through the normal review and ratification process, never by silent change.

Application

This principle is embodied in SPEC §1.2 Design Principle 2 (as amended) and SPEC §15.3. It means, concretely, that "the validator passed" is not a definition of compliance, and that tightening the validator to match a long-standing REQUIRED field is a correction rather than a breaking change - a distinction the specification's versioning policy and errata mechanism carry.

Scope

This decision states one principle only: the authority relationship between specification and validator. It does not classify document types (see GOVERNANCE.md) and does not record any specific historical change (see the relevant Change Note).

Sign-off

Maintainer	Decision	Approval date
Dr. Joan S. Muthu	Approved	2026-07-26
John Shalen R.	Approved	2026-07-26

Approval evidence: MD-0001-ApprovalEvidence-2026-07-26.pdf

Change log

Date	Change
2026-07-12	Initial draft (Proposed).

MD-0001 is a governance principle. It is non-normative with respect to dataset conformance: it changes no VIDS requirement and no validation rule; it states how the specification and validator relate.